



Episode 104: The 13th of Sivan: Ness Moussan
Translated by Morris Arking

Abraham Ades ('Antebi) of B'ne' B'raq has a manuscript from the collection of R. Moshe Sittehon (Aleppo 1797-1878) telling the story of Ness Moussan:

On the 12th of Sivan in 1853, on Shabbat afternoon before sunset a Christian woman came with two Christian men to the house of a Jewish man named Moshe Moussan. And the woman screamed "where is my son??? Yesterday he was playing with your son Yisshaq and now my son is missing!!!"

And she accused the Jews of murdering him like they had done to other children in the past in Damascus and in other places.

Then she called the local Muslim authorities and the Jewish boy Yisshaq Moussan was put in jail. The incident was reported to the Turkish authorities, and a complaint was made by the Christian clergy stating that it is impossible to live in the same city with the Jews because of their common practice of killing non-jewish children. Moshe Moussan was summonsed to appear. But since he was afraid, he hid. The Jews were very scared about the trouble that was about to ensue.

But on the following morning (13th of Sivan) a Protestant informed a Jew that the Christians were hiding the boy in order to vilify the Jews. The Jew ran to the Jewish neighborhood to inform them, and men were sent to the Christian woman's home, where they found her crying and complaining about the Jews who killed her son. They forcibly took a key to a courtyard from her, they opened the gate, entered and searched. In a room inside a room they found dirty clothes. Under the clothes they saw what looked like hair on someones head. They removed the clothes and found the boy. The boy was taken to the Muslims and they got a confession about the plot against the Jews.

The Rabbis of Halab declared that the 13th of Sivan should be observed every year by eliminating Tahanunim on that day.

Anyway on the 14th of Sivan a court case was arranged to incriminate the Christians. At first the Christian boy lied to the court. Then the lie was revealed but the court delayed in taking any action against the Christians, and it appeared that the Christian leader bribed the government officials to avoid being incriminated.